



The Road Ahead

- India may beef up its \$1.2-billion reconstruction and capacity-building projects.
- Will not send troops to Afghanistan but may provide logistical support to the US in case specific request is made.
- Would train the Afghan Army and provide non-lethal equipment.
- Enhance anti-terror cooperation with Afghanistan to tackle Pakistan-sponsored terrorism.

AFGHAN PRESIDENT KARZAI (RIGHT) WITH MUKHERJEE (CENTRE) DURING THE INAUGURATION OF THE ZARANJ-DELRAM HIGHWAY; (BELOW) OBAMA WITH HIS SPECIAL ENVOY HOLBROOKE

tionship, although not much is being said publicly. The menu includes more training slots for Afghan Army officers across India's top military academies, and, to begin with, consignments of non-lethal equipment for their security forces are also being explored. Currently, India and Afghanistan have been having regular consultations on intelligence-gathering through the two national security advisers and inter-agency cooperation. But faced with a resurgent and resilient Taliban aided by Pakistan, the two countries have felt the need to expand it exponentially. Experts say that Afghanistan is a strategic pivot for India, especially for its important anti-terror operations. They believe that in case Islamabad cannot be disciplined through diplomatic means, Afghanistan could prove to be an important

launching pad for covert action across the Afghan border. And with the US already making clear that it will not hesitate to strike militant hideouts in Pakistan, it is the sort of common cause that India is looking for.

In the changed context, India also faces a huge strategic dilemma about the US expectations over its involvement in the region. Will the Obama administration want to cut a deal with India, seeking its support in Afghanistan to neutralise the Taliban? Will its pressure on Pakistan-sponsored terrorism get diluted? Analysts believe that even though India does not have a military alliance with the US, Obama may expect strategic allies like India to shoulder some responsibilities. With some of his NATO allies like Canada already talking about reducing

troop commitments in Afghanistan, Obama's administration may want India to play a role. Top US army commanders have also indicated that India may have some role to play in the regional response that Obama has envisaged. "I think the strategic leadership and views, opinions and support provided by India will be very clear. India has taken significantly positive steps to invest in Afghanistan," US Joint Chiefs of Staff Chairman Admiral Mike Mullen said recently.

Some US experts warn against India getting militarily involved. Daniel Markey, senior fellow at the Council for Foreign Relations, says: "The new Obama administration will be sensitive to the fact that Indian troops are quite likely to raise tensions with Islamabad and encourage counter-productive regional reactions. I don't see India and the US crossing swords much at all. India's civilian development agenda is perceived as a valuable contribution. I don't believe that would have to change." Agreeing with him, Vanda Felbab-Brown, senior fellow, Brookings Institution in Washington D.C., adds: "Sending Indian troops into Afghanistan's territory is not an option. Productive cooperation will entail economic reconstruction and help with governance improvements and possibly civil society building."

India is moving cautiously and has indicated that the upgraded engagement will not include sending in its special forces as some countries want it to. New Delhi believes the solution to Afghanistan's problem cannot be through military means alone and that development has to be a key ingredient in which India can play a major role. So it wants to expand its capacity-building efforts of training more government officials, and the existing slot of 500 officers may be doubled. India should now engage with the US proactively to put in place a multilateral strategic cooperation in Afghanistan because even though the means may be different, its strategic interests are intertwined with the US to weed out terrorism in the region. ■